

indescribable pain in my penis. In the memory, I was very, very young. I could feel myself bleeding and bleeding, and a seemingly endless, searing pain on the tip of my penis. I dropped into this nightmare memory every day for weeks. I even developed hives ringing around the head of my penis, swelling up the area where I had been circumcised.

The traumatic memory of my circumcision took me so long to relive, I became suspicious that my circumcision was an unusually bad one. I also had memories of my mother's reaction to my body, which was extremely negative. So I called my mother and asked her about my circumcision. She told me that the doctor had cut too far, and the head of my penis was almost severed completely. The deep wound from the cut had bled for weeks, leaving me extremely weak. Every day when she changed my diapers, they were soaked with blood, and the scene was so grotesque that she literally threw up several times a week just from having to look at me when she changed my diapers. I was in need of medical help, but since I was the first child, my Mom didn't know it. I could have bled to death in those weeks. It took a process like Primal Therapy to unlock those memories and the terrible consequences they had on my sexual and personal development.

Circumcision, insidious because it is performed during the preverbal state, is recalled with intense feelings of terror and vulnerability. (Considering circumcision is only practiced by patriarchal societies with strong fraternal-interest groups, these specific feelings are obviously advantageous to the group maintaining control.) With the realization of personal injury and deprivation, other emotions emerge which clearly demonstrate the pain of circumcision does not cease when the wound heals.

Men who recognize their loss are enraged because part of their body was amputated without their consent. Others, sexually dysfunctional because of circumcision, have begun to ask for help. These are the victims of circumcision who must live with the tragic consequences of an unnecessary surgery for the rest of their lives. One man wrote:

Some of the problems that I have experienced because of circumcision are probably the most common. The main one is a decrease in the sensitivity of the glans, which other men have told me of also. The main problem with this is that I have difficulty in maintaining an erection without almost constant manipulation...I am not impotent...

I feel some resentment towards my parents because they took it upon themselves to have a part of my body cut off without my consent without any thought that I just might want that part of my body intact...

There have been times when I wished that my foreskin was intact. I have even gone so far as to use condoms, cut and placed in a tedious, time-consuming task, on myself to simulate a foreskin, so strong the desire to know what all of my original parts would feel like..."

While this man has tried to recapture his loss, others know exactly what it is they are missing. Men who have been circumcised as adults can help us understand how circumcision interferes with normal sexual functioning. I received the following letter from a man who was circumcised without his consent while he was under anesthesia.

I recovered clear consciousness to discover that I had been circumcised. Very obviously sincere and intense explanations by my medical friends smothered my irate objections. So it was that I was permanently deprived and the humorists deflated my complaints.